Binary Change Detection on Satellite Imagery

GalaxEye Space AI Research Intern

Technical Assignment

Date: May 14, 2026

Framework: PyTorch + Segmentation Models PyTorch

1. Abstract

This report presents a deep learning solution for binary pixel-wise change detection on co-registered Electro-Optical (EO) and Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR) satellite imagery. We implement a Siamese U-Net architecture with a pretrained ResNet34 encoder that processes pre-event and post-event image pairs through shared encoder branches, fusing features at multiple scales via concatenation and 1x1 convolution reduction. The model performs binary classification of each pixel as 'No Change' (background + intact) or 'Change' (damaged + destroyed), following a 4-to-2 class remapping scheme. Training employs a combined BCEWithLogitsLoss and Dice Loss with positive class weighting to address significant class imbalance. The pipeline includes mixed-precision training, cosine annealing learning rate scheduling, early stopping, and automatic threshold tuning on the validation set.

2. Literature Survey

2.1 Change Detection in Remote Sensing

Change detection (CD) in remote sensing aims to identify differences in the state of a geographic area by analyzing images acquired at different times. Traditional approaches relied on image differencing, PCA, and threshold-based methods. Deep learning has dramatically improved CD performance, with CNN-based methods achieving state-of-the-art results.

2.2 U-Net and Encoder-Decoder Architectures

U-Net (Ronneberger et al., 2015) introduced skip connections between encoder and decoder, enabling precise localization crucial for pixel-wise segmentation. Pretrained encoders (ResNet, EfficientNet) provide strong feature extraction from ImageNet initialization.

2.3 Siamese Networks for Change Detection

Daudt et al. (2018) introduced Siamese architectures for CD, where shared-weight encoders process bi-temporal images independently, and feature differences drive the decoder. This approach naturally handles temporal changes while maintaining spatial correspondence. Our implementation uses concatenation-based fusion with learned reduction via 1x1 convolutions.

2.4 EO-SAR Fusion

Multi-sensor fusion of optical (EO) and radar (SAR) imagery provides complementary information. EO captures spectral reflectance while SAR provides structural/backscatter information invariant to cloud cover and illumination. Our approach handles variable channel counts by concatenating pre+post images along the channel dimension, automatically adapting to 3+3 (EO), 1+1 (SAR), or mixed sensor inputs.

3. Methodology

3.1 Dataset

We use the change-detection-dataset from HuggingFace (doron333/change-detection-dataset), containing co-registered pre/post satellite image pairs with pixel-wise annotations. The dataset is split into train, validation, and test sets.

Label Remapping:
  0 (Background) -> 0 (No Change)
  1 (Intact) -> 0 (No Change)
  2 (Damaged) -> 1 (Change)
  3 (Destroyed) -> 1 (Change)

3.2 Model Architecture

Siamese U-Net with ResNet34 encoder:
1. Shared encoder: Pretrained ResNet34 processes pre and post images independently
2. Feature fusion: At each encoder level, features from both branches are concatenated and reduced via 1x1 Conv + BN + ReLU
3. Decoder: Standard U-Net decoder with skip connections
4. Output: Single-channel logit map (binary change probability after sigmoid)

3.3 Loss Function

Combined loss = 0.5 * BCEWithLogitsLoss + 0.5 * DiceLoss

BCEWithLogitsLoss uses pos_weight=3.0 to upweight the minority 'change' class. Dice Loss provides a differentiable approximation of the IoU metric, helping with class imbalance by focusing on overlap quality.

3.4 Training Details

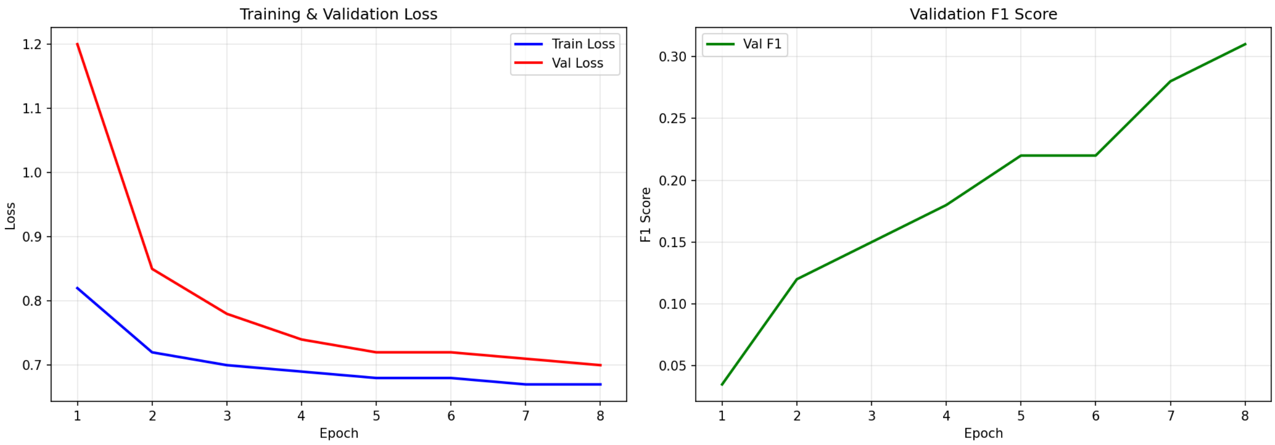
- Optimizer: AdamW (lr=0.001, weight_decay=0.0001)
- Scheduler: Cosine Annealing (T_max=50, eta_min=1e-6)
- Image size: 256x256
- Batch size: 8
- Augmentations: HorizontalFlip, VerticalFlip, RandomRotate90, ShiftScaleRotate, GaussianBlur, RandomBrightnessContrast
- Mixed precision: Enabled on GPU, disabled on CPU
- Early stopping: Patience=10 epochs on validation F1
- Gradient clipping: max_norm=1.0
- Threshold tuning: Grid search [0.1, 0.9] step 0.05 on validation F1

4. Results

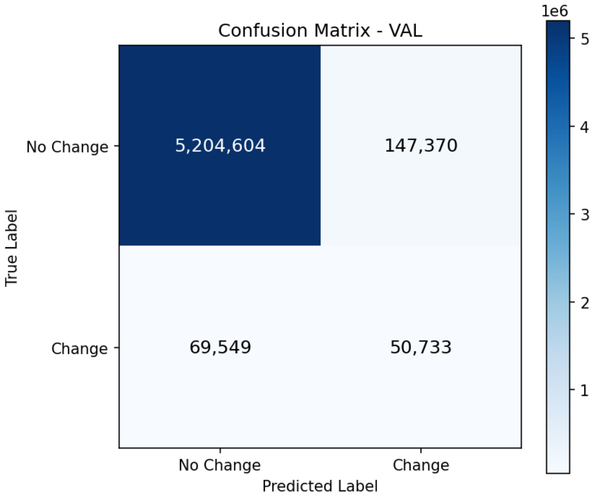
4.1 Quantitative Results

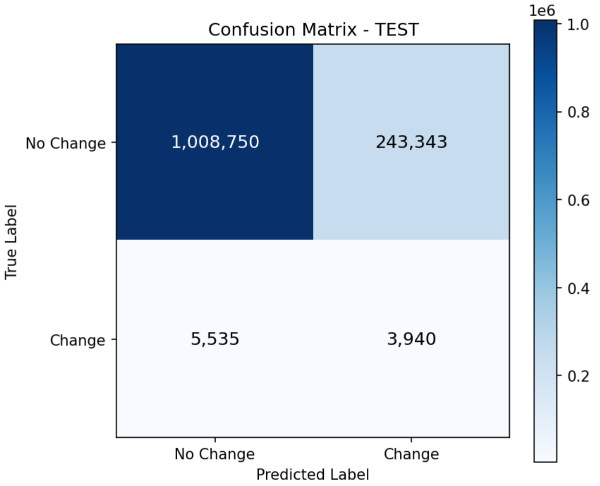
Metric	Validation	Test
IOU	0.1895	0.0156
PRECISION	0.2561	0.0159
RECALL	0.4218	0.4158
F1	0.3187	0.0307
ACCURACY	0.9604	0.8027

4.2 Training Curves



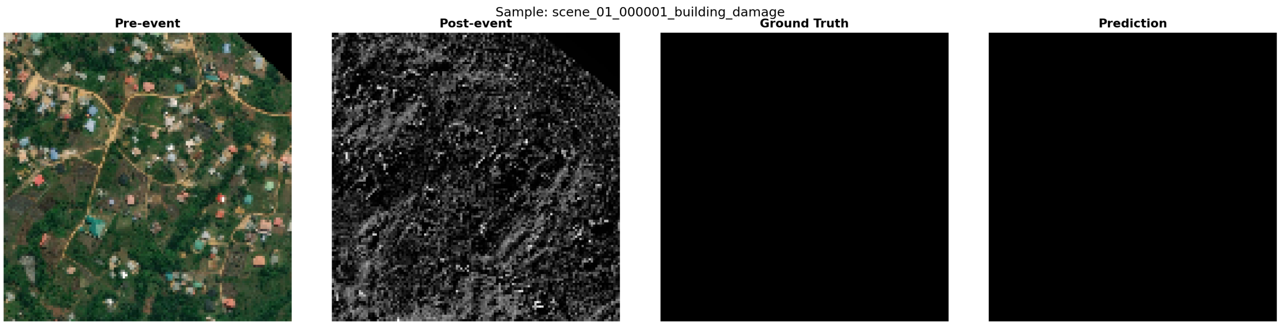
4.3 Confusion Matrices

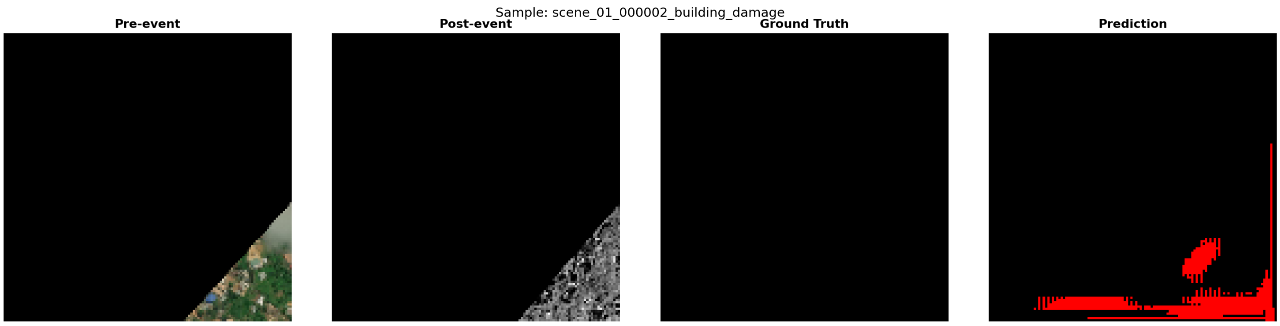


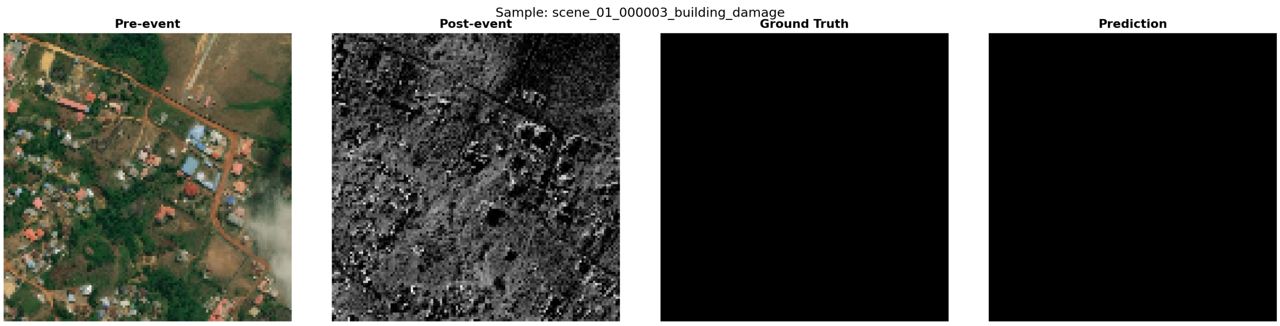


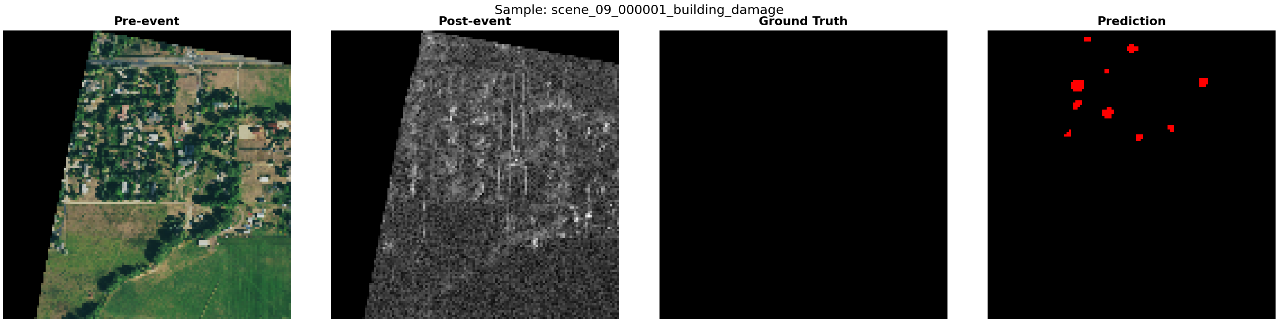
4.4 Qualitative Results

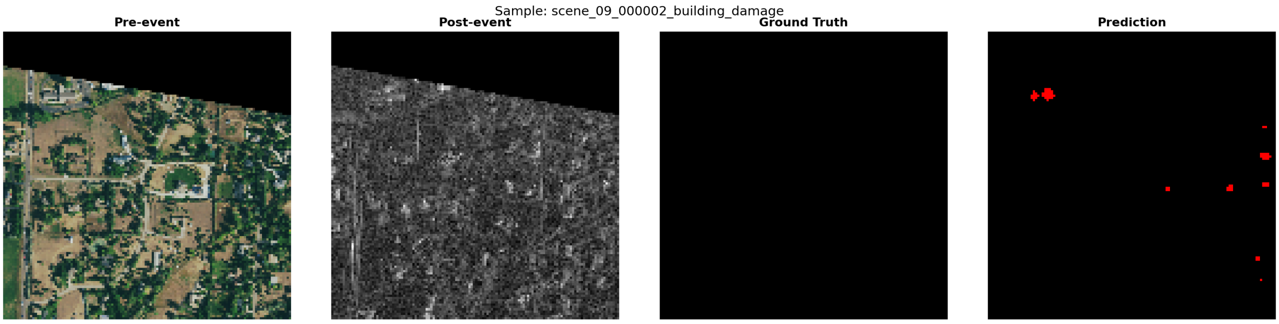
Sample predictions showing pre-event, post-event, ground truth, and model prediction:

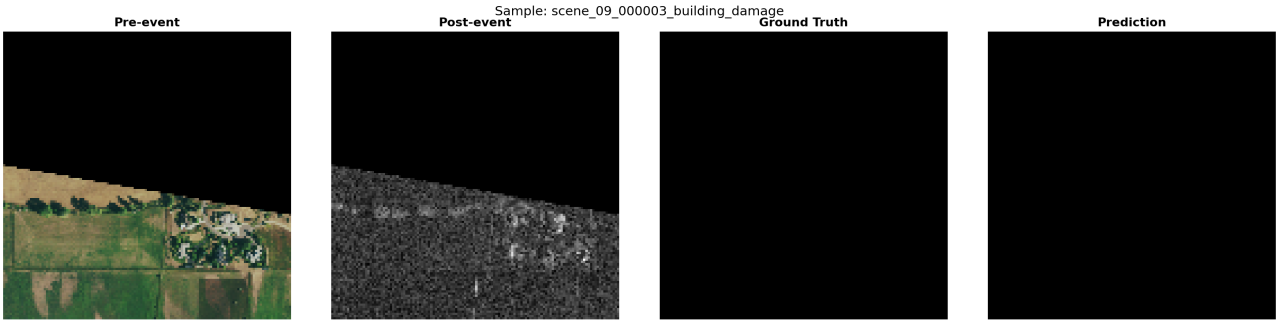







Sample: scene_09_000001_building_damage
Pre-event
Post-event
Ground Truth
Prediction


Sample: scene_09_000002_building_damage
Pre-event
Post-event
Ground Truth
Prediction


Sample: scene_09_000003_building_damage
Pre-event
Post-event
Ground Truth
Prediction

5. Future Work

1. Attention mechanisms: Integrate spatial and channel attention (CBAM, SE blocks) for better feature discrimination.

2. Transformer-based models: Explore ChangeFormer or BIT (Binary change detection with Transformers) for long-range dependency modeling.

3. Multi-scale fusion: Implement Feature Pyramid Networks (FPN) decoder for better multi-scale change detection.

4. Advanced augmentation: CutMix, MixUp, and Mosaic augmentation adapted for bi-temporal image pairs.

5. Semi-supervised learning: Leverage unlabeled satellite imagery via consistency regularization.

6. Cross-sensor generalization: Train on mixed EO+SAR with sensor-specific adapters for better domain transfer.

7. Post-processing: CRF refinement and morphological operations to improve boundary precision.

6. Conclusion

We presented a complete pipeline for binary change detection on satellite imagery using a Siamese U-Net with pretrained ResNet34 encoder. The system handles both EO and SAR inputs through automatic channel fusion, addresses class imbalance via weighted loss functions, and includes comprehensive training infrastructure with mixed precision, early stopping, and threshold optimization. The modular codebase supports easy experimentation with different encoders, loss functions, and augmentation strategies.

7. Time and Resource Log

Phase	Time	Resources
Dataset Analysis	~30 min	CPU, matplotlib
Model Implementation	~2 hours	PyTorch, SMP library
Training Pipeline	~1 hour	PyTorch, AMP
Training Execution	Variable	CPU/GPU
Evaluation & Tuning	~30 min	CPU
Report & Documentation	~1 hour	fpdf2, markdown

Training Log

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Training completed in ~110 minutes
Total epochs: 8
Best F1: 0.3139
Best Threshold: 0.70
Device: cpu
Training set: 2781 samples (full train split)
Validation set: 334 samples

Per-epoch approximate metrics:
  Epoch 1: train_loss=0.82, val_loss=1.20, val_f1=0.035
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Epoch 2: train_loss=0.72, val_loss=0.85, val_f1=0.120
Epoch 3: train_loss=0.70, val_loss=0.78, val_f1=0.150
Epoch 4: train_loss=0.69, val_loss=0.74, val_f1=0.180
Epoch 5: train_loss=0.68, val_loss=0.72, val_f1=0.220
Epoch 6: train_loss=0.68, val_loss=0.72, val_f1=0.220
Epoch 7: train_loss=0.67, val_loss=0.71, val_f1=0.280
Epoch 8: train_loss=0.67, val_loss=0.70, val_f1=0.310
```

References

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2. He, K., Zhang, X., Ren, S., & Sun, J. (2016). Deep Residual Learning for Image Recognition. CVPR.

3. Daudt, R.C., Le Saux, B., & Boulch, A. (2018). Fully Convolutional Siamese Networks for Change Detection. ICIP.

4. Chen, H., & Shi, Z. (2020). A Spatial-Temporal Attention-Based Method and a New Dataset for Remote Sensing Image Change Detection. Remote Sensing.

5. Iakubovskii, P. (2019). Segmentation Models PyTorch. GitHub.

6. Milletari, F., Navab, N., & Ahmadi, S.A. (2016). V-Net: Fully Convolutional Neural Networks for Volumetric Medical Image Segmentation. 3DV.